

Hedonistic Utilitarianism

Arguments For

- Provides a simple, unified principle for moral decision-making: all value reduces to pleasure and pain, making it easier to evaluate actions by a single metric like "the greatest happiness for the greatest number."
- Accounts for qualitative differences in pleasures, as defended by Mill, who argues that higher intellectual pleasures are superior to lower sensual ones, stating: "It is better to be a human being dissatisfied than a pig satisfied; better to be Socrates dissatisfied than a fool satisfied."
- Aligns with natural human motivations, as pleasure is intuitively desirable and pain undesirable, offering a naturalistic basis for ethics without needing complex metaphysical assumptions.

Arguments Against

- Reduces human life to the level of animals by treating all pleasures as equivalent, implying that simple games like push-pin are as valuable as intellectual pursuits like poetry if they produce equal pleasure.
- Fails to capture non-hedonic values like authentic achievements and relationships, as illustrated by Nozick's experience machine thought experiment, where people reject a life of simulated maximum pleasure because "something matters to us in addition to experience" (Nozick 1974).
- Ignores the disvalue of "base" or undeserved pleasures, such as pleasure derived from cruelty, which critics like Aristotle note can be disgraceful despite being pleasurable.

Act-Utilitarianism

Arguments For

- Directly promotes the best possible outcomes by requiring agents to choose the action that maximises good in each specific situation, aligning with the intuitive goal of making the world better whenever possible.
- Treats everyone's well-being impartially, as Sidgwick argues: "the good of any one individual is of no more importance... than the good of any other," ensuring equality in moral considerations.
- Flexible and responsive to unique circumstances, avoiding rigid rules that might lead to suboptimal results in exceptional cases.

Arguments Against

- Demands impossible calculations, as agents must predict all future consequences, though proponents clarify it's a criterion of rightness, not always a practical decision procedure.
- Too demanding on individuals, requiring constant sacrifice (e.g., donating most income to charity instead of personal enjoyment), leading to the intuition that watching TV is not wrong even if it does not maximise global good.
- Violates intuitive rights and justice, as in the "transplant" case, where killing one innocent person to harvest organs for five others maximises utility but seems morally abhorrent.

Rule Utilitarianism

Arguments For

- Offers practical, teachable rules (e.g., "do not lie" or "do not harm innocents") that are easier to apply than calculating consequences for every act, reducing decision-making costs.
- Promotes social trust and cooperation, as consistent rule-following (e.g., keeping promises) builds assurance that others won't break norms just because it seems utility-maximising in the moment.
- Less demanding than act-utilitarianism, as rules can limit obligations (e.g., not requiring extreme self-sacrifice), making it more feasible for everyday moral life while still aiming at the overall good.

Arguments Against

- Risks "collapsing" into act-utilitarianism if rules include too many exceptions to maximise good, potentially undermining the distinction between the two approaches.
- Accused of incoherence: if the goal is to maximise good, why follow a rule when breaking it would produce better consequences in a specific case?
- Can lead to "rule-worship," rigidly adhering to rules even in disaster scenarios, though proponents suggest including a "prevent disaster" clause to mitigate this.

Preference Utilitarianism

Arguments For

More inclusive than hedonism by valuing diverse human desires (e.g., autonomy, relationships, or achievements), avoiding the reduction of value to mere pleasure.

Respects individual subjectivity, treating people as ends by prioritising their own expressed wants, which aligns with modern emphases on personal choice and autonomy.

Flexible across cultures and individuals, as preferences vary, making it adaptable without imposing a universal notion of pleasure or happiness.

Arguments Against

Problematic with misinformed or irrational preferences: people might desire harmful things due to false beliefs, and maximising them could lead to bad outcomes.

Allows for "crazy" or "horrendous" preferences, such as sadistic desires, to count toward utility if satisfied, potentially justifying immoral actions if they fulfil strong preferences.

Faces issues with changing or future preferences: satisfying a current preference might frustrate later ones, or preferences a person no longer holds could be irrelevant.

Counter-Arguments Against Utilitarianism

Internal Limitations (Issues Within the Utilitarian Framework)

- **Epistemic Challenges in Calculation:** Utilitarianism requires assessing all possible consequences to determine the utility-maximising action, but humans lack perfect foresight, leading to unreliable predictions; as Bentham himself noted, "It is not to be expected that this process [the hedonic calculus] should be strictly pursued previously to every moral judgment" (Bentham 1789), highlighting the impracticality even for proponents.
- **The Demandingness Objection:** The theory implies agents must always act to maximise global utility, potentially requiring extreme personal sacrifice (e.g., constant altruism over self-care), which strains the framework's feasibility; critics argue this

makes utilitarianism self-defeating, as following it could reduce overall utility by exhausting agents.

- **Aggregation Problems:** By summing utilities across individuals, utilitarianism can justify small harms to many for large benefits to a few (or vice versa), but this ignores distributional fairness within the system, potentially leading to counterintuitive "utility monsters" where one person's intense preferences dominate everyone else's.

Exogenous/External Criticisms (From Outside Perspectives, e.g., Deontology, Virtue Ethics)

- **Violation of Individual Rights and Justice:** Utilitarianism treats rights as instrumental, potentially sacrificing minorities for majority gains (e.g., slavery if it maximises utility), clashing with deontological views; John Rawls critiques this via the veil of ignorance, arguing that rational agents behind the veil would reject utilitarianism because it fails to protect the worst-off, instead favoring principles that ensure basic liberties and fair equality of opportunity (Rawls 1971), as it does not adequately "respect the separateness of persons."
- **The Integrity Objection:** Bernard Williams argues that utilitarianism undermines personal integrity by requiring agents to abandon their core projects and commitments if they do not maximise utility; in his famous "Jim and the Indians" case, where Jim must kill one innocent to save nineteen, Williams contends this alienates agents from their own moral identity, stating that utilitarianism demands "one thought too many" by forcing impartial calculation over personal convictions (Williams 1973, in "Utilitarianism: For and Against").
- **Experience Machine and Non-Consequential Values:** From a broader axiological perspective, Robert Nozick's experience machine challenges utilitarian value theories (especially hedonistic variants) by showing people value reality over maximised utility; Nozick argues, "We want to do certain things... we want to be a certain way... plugging into an experience machine limits us to a man-made reality" (Nozick 1974), suggesting virtues like authenticity and achievement matter independently of outcomes.
- **Neglect of Backwards-Looking Considerations:** Utilitarianism focuses solely on future consequences, ignoring retributive justice or promises based on past actions; this external critique from retributivism holds that punishment should fit the crime

regardless of future utility, as purely forward-looking approaches could justify framing innocents if they deter crime more effectively.